



Research paper

Wrestling with forum theater in the banking culture of education in the United States: A self-study

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ABSTRACT

This self-study explores the complexities of implementing forum theater as a pedagogical strategy in a course on guidance practices for young children. Through analysis of teacher candidate exit tickets, interviews, researcher memos, and researcher meeting notes, we found forum theater promoted playfulness, embodied learning, and learning from peers. We also found instructor and teacher candidates faced difficulties overcoming the banking model of education to implement forum theater as it was intended. Difficulties manifested in resistance to participation, focus on memorization, and seeing the instructor as giver-of-knowledge. We provide implications for our own practice that might be applied in other contexts.

1. Introduction

Students of Color and students identified as differently abled are disproportionately disciplined in United States (US) schools (Civil Rights Data Collection, 2021). Beginning in preschool, Black students are suspended and expelled at a higher rate than their white counterparts (U.S. Department of Education, 2016). School administrations are also more likely to refer Black student to law enforcement as a part of discipline measures (U.S. Department of Education, 2016). Indigenous, Latinx, and multiracial boys and children with disabilities are disproportionately suspended in primary and secondary public schools (United States Department of Education Office of Civil Rights, 2016). These inequities are perpetuated at the system level through discipline models that mirror the culture of prison (Annamma & Handy, 2019; Noguera, 2003) and at the interpersonal level through teacher and administrator interactions with students influenced by internal bias (Bryan, 2017; Gilliam & Reyes, 2018; Sabol et al., 2021).

Teacher preparation programs in the United States are not effectively preparing teachers to disrupt ongoing cycles of discipline disparities. Despite advocacy by national early childhood education organizations to ground courses in sociocultural and constructivist theories and conceptualize social-emotional teaching as child guidance, many preparation programs continue to ground courses in behaviorist theory, conceptualizing teachers as managers (Thomas, 2019; Thomas & Liu,

under review). Teacher preparation programs have been found to dedicate limited time to preparing teachers to support the social-emotional needs of students and facilitate a community of learners (Buettner et al., 2016; Flower et al., 2017). According to the U. S. Department of United States Department of Education (2018), only 55.1% of early career public school teachers reported being well-prepared to handle a range of classroom management (p. 29, Appendix A). Further, Chang-Bacon (2022) found teacher educators actively engage in race-evasiveness in their courses. Institutions that grant degrees in teacher education and the instructors who work within those programs have a responsibility to prepare teachers to meet the emotional and social needs of their students rather than succumbing to the culture of harsh punishment. Transformational pedagogies are needed to raise educator awareness of harmful discipline practices and prepare them to teach counter to dominant norms. However, such transformational pedagogies cannot be taken up haphazardly or without major shifts in traditional approaches to education and significant educator introspection (Hollins, 2015).

In this self-study, we examine our implementation of forum theater as a pedagogical strategy to promote teacher candidate (TC) efficacy with positive child guidance strategies in a larger U.S. context marked by oppressive discipline practices. The research question that guides our work is, *What are the benefits and challenges of implementing forum theater in a child guidance course that aims to prepare early childhood teachers to*

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employ positive child guidance strategies?

2. Forum theater as transformational pedagogy

Our study is grounded in notions of transformational education as articulated by Freire (1970). Transformational education stands in contrast to the banking model of education (Freire, 1970) dominant in U.S. schooling from the preschool to university level. We utilized pedagogies described by Boal (1979) as *Theater of the Oppressed*. Boal's theater pedagogies are designed to increase critical consciousness, disrupt the false mind/body dichotomy endorsed in the banking model of education, and prepare participants for social action. We look specifically at Boal's (1979) *forum theater*, a pedagogy that utilizes a facilitator called a *Joker*.

2.1. The banking model of education

Rhianna implemented forum theater in an attempt to disrupt the banking model of education that serves to maintain the inequitable status quo in the PK-20 education system and broader U.S. society. Freire (1970) conceived of the banking model of education as a metaphor to understand the stagnant nature of schooling in which the instructor is understood as the giver-of-knowledge and students as passive receivers-of-knowledge. Freire (1970) asserted the banking model of education "mirror[s] oppressive society as a whole" (p. 73), limits students' creativity, and increases their willingness to comply with hegemonic systems. A requisite goal of transformative education is the attainment of critical consciousness, the ability to recognize and analyze social inequalities and the systems that maintain them. Transformative education builds upon students' cultural knowledge, is organized around problem-posing, and results in social action (Carnoy & Tarlau, 2019; Freire, 1970).

The No Child Left Behind Act of 2002 prompted increases in standardized and high-stakes testing in U.S. primary and secondary schools. These accountability measures led to a deepening of the banking model of education by narrowing curriculum, objectifying students and teachers, and positioning teachers as proxies for the state (Bybee, 2020). This means U.S. education stakeholders have been socialized and educated within the banking model of education for upwards of 20 years. Teachers who have been educated and socialized in this system are unlikely to possess the critical consciousness required to "deflect deficit notions embodied commonsensically within the classroom" (Darder, 2016, p. 2) and critically examine "larger conditions of inequalities that shape the lives of historically oppressed populations" (Darder, 2016, p. 2). Indeed, even practitioners who seek to enact transformational pedagogy have been found to dull such teaching practices within the larger culture of the banking model (Giroux, 1992; Macedo, 2000).

2.2. Theater of the oppressed

Freire (1970) asserted transformational pedagogy is grounded in the notion that knowledge is constructed through collaborative and hopeful experiences that promote curiosity and problem-solving about local issues. Inspired by Freire's work and in reaction to political turmoil in Brazil in the 1960s, Augusto Boal, a Brazilian political activist and theater practitioner, developed *Theater of the Oppressed* (Souto-Manning et al., 2008). Like Freire's assertion that education is always political (Freire, 1970), Boal (1979) asserted politics and theatre are inseparable. Left in the hands of the ruling class, theatre becomes a tool for domination that renders spectators passive recipients of information (Boal, 1979). Recognizing the power of theater for consciousness-raising and political disruption, Boal developed dramatic forms to upset the barrier between actors and audience, expose politics inherent in traditional theatre (Boal, 1979), and "promote dialogue and consciousness among peasants in disempowered rural areas"

(Souto-Manning et al., 2008, p. 312). Among the techniques Boal developed are *Image Theater*, *Forum Theater*, *Invisible Theater*, *Cops in the Head*, and *Rainbow of Desire* (Boal, 1979).

2.2.1. The Joker

In the spirit of liberation, Boal's theater techniques are facilitated by a Joker instead of a director (Boal, 1979; Gökdağ, 2014). Boal used the word *Joker* to emulate the flexibility of the role of the Joker in card games, a card often mobile compared to other cards. The Joker performs different roles "including director, referee, facilitator, and workshop leader. The Joker might also play various roles: actor, character, chorus, and protagonist, all in the same performance" (Gökdağ, 2014, p. 31). The Joker sets guidelines, facilitates the development of scenarios, and engages participants in a dialogue to determine the reality of multiple solutions. The Joker might be thought of as a *difficultator* (Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010) who deepens the conversation to build critical consciousness and practical problem-solving skills.

2.2.2. Liberating the body

Transformational pedagogies support both embodied and intellectual responses to oppression. They are grounded in the understanding that separation of mind and body is a false dichotomy instituted in mainstream culture to control bodies and separate people from concrete problems (Darder, 2016). Boal observed that ways of moving through the world become normalized and serve to mechanize the body and mind and limit change (Boal, 1979). He understood bodily awareness to be prerequisite to participation in transformative theater pedagogies such as forum theater. Thus, Boal (1979, 1992) established games and exercises to increase creativity and comfort with bodily expression. These games included pairing one's name with a gesture, one partner controlling or mirroring another, and forming the body into a statue or frozen scene (Boal, 1992).

2.2.3. Forum theater

Once participants achieve increased bodily awareness and comfort in movement, forum theatre may be employed. In forum theatre, participants, led by a Joker, share compelling experiences then select a scenario that represents a common problematic experience (Boal, 1979; Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010). Participants act out the problematic scenario. While the scene is reenacted, audience members, or *spect-actors*, can pause the act and replace any actor to lead the scene to their proposed solution (Boal, 1979; Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010). Participants may reenact scenes several times to explore different resolutions to a problem. Once a scene is completed, participants evaluate the reality of any solution presented. Adapted approaches might be acted out based on this *reality check* (Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010). The goal of forum theater is not to find a perfect solution but to "seek options, to debate alternatives, and to cultivate a sense of multiplicity, flexibility, and possibilities for change" (Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010, p. 93). Forum theater allows participants to voice their ideas and build confidence, transitioning from observers to people who are willing to collaborate and act.

3. Forum theater in practice

Forum theater has been utilized in a variety of settings to increase critical consciousness and rehearse innovative responses to oppression. In the United Kingdom, Cardboard Citizens engages people who have experienced homelessness in productions performed in prisons, hospitals, and shelters (Cardboard Citizens, n.d.; Tempest, 2014). Hammond (2015) described forum theater techniques used to help British Year Six students manage transitions such as promotion to secondary school, divorce, and geographical relocation. In India, Jana Sanskriti, stages productions to engage rural audiences in critical examination of

domestic violence, child marriage, and maternal health (Brahma et al., 2019). The 2006 People's Movement in Nepal sparked a proliferation of kachahari natak, a form of forum theater performed on the streets to address issues including indentured child labor (Mottin, 2018). Prosper Kompaor's Atelie Théâtre Burkinabé combines forum theater with Indigenous African performance to increase conversation around a wide range of topics including the AIDS epidemic (Plastow, 2009; UNESCO, 2005). In Australia and New Zealand, forum theater has been adapted in schools as a tool for bullying prevention (Burton & O'Toole, 2005).

4. Forum theater in teacher education

Forum theater has been taken up by teacher educators as a pedagogical technique to increase critical consciousness (Harman & McClure, 2011; McDermott et al., 2012), develop perspective-taking skills (Briones et al., 2022; Desai, 2017), support application of theory to practice (Desai, 2017; Eriksen et al., 2015; Wells et al., 2023), and develop discursive skills for the field (Caldas, 2017, 2018; Hogan, 2014; Souto-Manning et al., 2008; Stillman et al., 2019). Forum theater has been utilized in a variety of teacher education spaces. University instructors have used forum theater in undergraduate courses on multicultural education (Desai, 2017; McDermott et al., 2012), culturally relevant pedagogy (Powers & McClure, 2016), bilingual education (Caldas, 2017, 2018), field-based seminars (Erikson et al., 2015; Hogan, 2014), and graduate courses in literacy (Harman & McClure, 2011; McDermott et al., 2012) and foundations of education (McDermott et al., 2012). In New Zealand, where drama is considered a core subject, TCs might experience forum theater in their methods courses (Hogan, 2014; Wells et al., 2023). Many studies of forum theater are conducted outside of university classrooms in participant-selected spaces such as study groups (Stillman et al., 2019), researcher-constructed spaces (Briones et al., 2022), and professional development programs for practicing teachers (Harman & McClure, 2011; Souto-Manning et al., 2008).

Researchers have found forum theater requires teachers and teacher educators to apply theoretical and ethical principles to concrete situations, increasing engagement and practical knowledge (Desai, 2017; Eriksen et al., 2015; Hogan, 2014; Stillman et al., 2019). Forum theater supports practical application and raising critical consciousness because it is organized around a scenario that is problematized. Desai (2017) described a moment in his undergraduate course when TCs reacted to a discussion prompt about anti-immigration legislation with silence. To engage TCs, Desai (2017) decided to enact forum theater around a teaching scenario in which "A student asks a teacher what does she or he think about these recent immigration laws" (p. 232). Scenario-based forum theater led students to take on the perspective of an undocumented student, ask questions about teachers' ethical and legal responsibilities, and try out different responses. Desai (2017) concluded forum theater utilizes concrete scenarios to engage students in critical reflection, increasing their understanding of systemic inequality when they resist such work in typical classroom interactions. Our review of the literature found most facilitators utilized participant-generated scenarios grounded in participants' life experiences and field-based observations (Briones et al., 2022; Eriksen et al., 2015; Harman & McClure, 2011; Hogan, 2014; McDermott et al., 2012; Souto-Manning et al., 2008; Stillman et al., 2019). However, we found some facilitators who work with TCs with limited field experience, utilized instructor-generated scenarios (Desai, 2017) or scenarios collected from practicing teachers (Caldas, 2017, 2018).

Forum theater has been found to be a safe space for practicing teachers and TCs to discuss sensitive topics and rehearse potentially transformative actions away from the demands of the field (Harman & McClure, 2011; Hogan, 2014; Souto-Manning et al., 2008; Stillman et al., 2019). Stillman et al. (2019) described *cocoon-like* safety of forum theater in the university classroom as a place that "nurtures consciousness-raising, risk-taking, and embodied understandings" (p. 448). Stillman et al. (2019) assert forum theater supports Freire's call to

be *patiently impatient* by rehearsing concrete strategies to address deficit language about students and families before attempting such strategies in the field.

While many studies laud the effectiveness of forum theater, some find it somewhat complicated to enact as it requires a foundational shift in approaches to teacher education. Desai (2017) pointed out forum theater requires the facilitator to resist the urge to offer counterpoints or direct students to think about educational issues in the abstract and instead facilitate rumination through acting on a concrete scenario. The Joker facilitating forum theater must be adept at asking questions and providing prompts that awaken critical consciousness. Harman and McClure (2011) found providing a *critical reflection sheet* was not enough to lead facilitators or spect-actors to "think about the socio-political factors that informed the tensions in the scenario" (p. 392). They conclude it is easier to identify problematic discourses acted out by antagonists, "but more difficult to identify our own discursive 'habitus' and ways of seeing the world that clearly manifest in how we perform and discuss our lived experiences" (Harman & McClure, 2011, p. 395). Further, Powers and Duffy (2016) recognized power dynamics at play between university instructors and students may impact the transformative potential of forum theater. They assert students may perform critical consciousness and transformative action in the university classroom only to please instructors and earn good grades.

Taking into consideration the transformative potential of forum theater as pedagogy and the potential difficulties in enacting forum theater in the undergraduate teacher preparation classroom, we engaged in critical reflection on our own teaching practices. In this paper, we examine our use of forum theater in a TC preparation course on child guidance and classroom management practices, a context in which forum theater has potential to support transformational teacher education but has been under-studied.

5. Methods

Self-study is the systematic examination of one's own teaching practices informed by theory, introspection, and feedback from critical friends and other stakeholders (Loughran, 2007; Pithouse-Morgan, 2022). The purpose of self-study is both to improve one's practice and to make "accessible... the underlying knowledge/ideas/theories that influence teachers' pedagogical reasoning" (Hamilton, 2004, p. 401). The methods of self-study vary depending on the context and goals of the study (Pithouse-Morgan, 2022), and methods may change or be augmented throughout the study due to the natural interplay between research and practice (Loughran, 2007). The validity and trustworthiness of self-study are determined according to the researcher(s)' ability to interrogate their own assumptions and practices, engage in critical collaboration, maintain relational ethics, conduct meticulous and transparent data collection and analysis procedures, provide evidence of impact on practice, and share the work publicly (LaBoskey, 2004; Loughran, 2007; Pithouse-Morgan, 2022). In this section, we endeavor toward trustworthiness by describing our positionality as teacher-researchers, introducing the context and participants of the study, and describing our data collection and analysis procedures.

5.1. Teacher-researchers

Rhianna designed and taught the course in which the study took place. Thomas worked as a graduate research assistant supporting Rhianna in carrying out the study. Thomas helped explicate the theory around transformation pedagogy and checked consistency between theory and practice (Berry, 2004). Thomas acted as a participant-observer and critical friend, a fundamental role in self-study (Alan et al., 2021). He led some brief warm-up activities and attended most classes. His familiarity with class happenings and the intended philosophy of practice allowed Thomas to provide provocative questions and constructive feedback to Rhianna, increasing validity and credibility

of the study (Alan et al., 2021; Stolle et al., 2019). In recognition that “dangers seen, unseen, and unforeseen can emerge for researchers when they do not pay careful attention to their own and others’ racialized and cultural systems of coming to know, knowing, and experiencing the world” (Milner, 2007, p. 388), we explore our positionalities here.

Rhianna is a white, monolingual, female assistant professor of early childhood education. She has more than fifteen years of experience teaching in racially and ability diverse toddler, preschool, and elementary spaces. One of Rhianna’s research interests is equity in child guidance and discipline practices. Upon the writing of this paper, she had taught a course on guiding young children for five years across two different universities. She had incorporated role play and forum theater in her teaching for four years.

During the writing of this manuscript, Thomas was a doctoral candidate studying Curriculum and Instruction with a focus on Learning Design and Technology. He was a graduate research assistant and secondary education supervisor and had been observing practicum students since 2017. Thomas is an African male who has experience in diverse cultures and learning environments in Ghana, Russia, and the United States. His research interests include digital learning, technology and culture, and critical pedagogy. He is inspired by the work of Paulo Freire. Thomas worked as Rhianna’s graduate assistant for five semesters. We established routines of discussion that supported critical conversations and honest critique.

5.2. Context

Our study took place at a Hispanic and Minority Serving Institution in the Southwest United States. Neither Rhianna nor Thomas are long-time residents of the context in which the study took place. Rhianna had been residing in the Southwest United States for 2 years at the time of data collection and Thomas for four years. *Guiding Young Children* is a required course for students seeking degrees in early childhood education, both licensure and non-licensure routes. Course objectives center helping children develop self-regulation, positive self-image, and healthy relationships through interactions, routines, and physical environment. Course assignments include teaching dilemmas and development of classroom procedures and routines. The course is taken before admission to the Teacher Education Program, so students are often first and second year university students who have had limited coursework and formal field experiences regarding early education. However, across semesters, some students who take the course have been or are currently working as teaching assistants in childcare and educational settings.

5.2.1. Raising critical consciousness in the course

Rhianna employed several tactics to raise TC critical consciousness around discipline disparities and harmful discipline practices. She grounded the course in critical sociocultural theory, asserting we all learn ways of operating in the world that perpetuate or work against oppression (Freire, 1970; Lewis & Moje, 2003). She also shared historical foundations and current research on discipline disparities and the effects of unconscious bias. Throughout the course, Rhianna referenced Annamma’s (2018) framework for understanding oppressive discipline practice: Hyper punishment, hyper surveillance, and hyper labeling of students.

5.2.2. Enacting forum theater in the course

Rhianna began the semester with movement exercises such as *What’s in a Name*, *How Many As in an A*, and *Stopping Around* (Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010). TCs laughed together, sometimes hesitated and demurred, and slowly seemed more energetic and comfortable with movement and each other. After several weeks, Rhianna began implementing forum theater as a pedagogical tool. Due to the limited teaching experiences of the students, Rhianna introduced many scenarios. However, she also provided opportunities for students to share scenarios of concern to be analyzed through forum theater. The forum theater

routine used in the course is as follows:

1. Instructor or TCs share a scenario around the current topic of study (such as peer conflict).
2. The group discusses salient elements of the story briefly (age and developmental level of child, possible perspective and emotional state of teacher, etc.).
3. TCs and instructor select roles and act out the scenario.
4. Spect-actors and the Joker may stop the scene, provide comment, and step in to try a different approach. (The Joker seeks to foster critical consciousness of the harmful nature of some established classroom practices through questions/comments).
5. The Joker facilitates a reality check with the entire group to discuss the authenticity of responses, possible perspectives, and feasibility of actions.

5.3. Participants

The participants were students enrolled in *Guiding Young Children* during Fall 2021. Students were freshmen through seniors, parents, and assistant teachers. Twenty-two students were enrolled in the course at the end of the semester. To reduce coercion, Thomas shared information about the study when Rhianna was out of the classroom, no incentives were offered for participation, and interviews were scheduled after grades were submitted. Fourteen students consented to participate in the study. On the consent form, students were directed to select which data sources they would like to opt in to. They could choose to only share exit tickets as data, and had the option to participate in a 30-min interview that would take place after grades had been submitted for the course. All fourteen students who consented to participate in the study gave permission for their exit tickets to be analyzed. Seven students consented to interview, but only four students responded to interview requests which were sent after the last class. Students who were interviewed chose a pseudonym during the interview. The researchers selected pseudonyms for remaining participants.

5.4. Data sources

Self-study has a dual focus on the self as educator and on the effectiveness of practice (Pithouse-Morgan, 2022), thus our data set consists of both student-generated and teacher-researcher-generated data. Student-generated data consists of exit tickets and interviews. Teacher-researcher-generated data consists of individual reflections and research meeting notes. We explain each in more detail below.

5.4.1. Exit tickets

Exit tickets were collected at the end of in-person class sessions and consisted of instructor-provided questions about the topics and activities of the class. Thirteen sets of exit tickets were collected throughout the semester. When forum theater was used in class, exit tickets included prompts about the students’ experiences with the practice. The following are representative of typical exit ticket prompts focusing on forum theater:

- Did you find the forum theater activity useful? Why or why not?
- What would you change about the forum theater activity?
- Did the scenarios and solutions we tried in forum theater seem realistic to you? Why or why not?
- What was the most helpful part of our class today (Power Point, Reader’s Theater, reality check, scenarios in small group, whole group theater, other)? Why?

5.4.2. Teacher-researcher reflections and collaborative teacher-researcher meeting notes

Rhianna was the instructional designer and enacted all forum theater sessions throughout the course. Thomas attended most class sessions as

an observer. Each teacher-researcher wrote individual reflections on course happenings informed by readings on transformational pedagogy and Theater of the Oppressed. These reflections supported regular conversations between Thomas and Rhianna that took place before and/or after class sessions. Russell (2006) asserts, "Self-study relies on interaction with close colleagues who can listen actively and constructively" (p. 5). Throughout the study, we maintained a professional relationship characterized by candid discussions necessary for self-study. For example, Rhianna's reflection on Oct. 24, 2021 included the following, "Is it my responsibility to teach them a process/skill and then give them opportunities to select from a menu of strategies AND create own solutions?" When she shared this question with Thomas, he responded, "Your role is to guide them to know some strategies. You would explain to them some approaches, but they are not fixed, they are possibilities. [The students will] have to think of what [they] know right now and be able to adapt it to fit [their] context."

5.4.3. Student interviews

Rhianna interviewed participants at the end of the semester after student grades had been posted. Interviews were conducted over Zoom and lasted about 30 min each. Interviews were focused on the experience of forum theater and based on each participant's unique engagement with forum theater as indicated by exit slips and field notes. Examples of interview prompts include:

- Let's start with you talking about your experience of forum theater to support your child guidance skills. How did forum theater affect your learning in this class/professional development?
- In your exit slips, you often mentioned _____. Tell me more about that.
- In your exit slip after our session practicing peer conflict resolution, you wrote _____. Talk some more about your experience in that session.

After all interviews were completed, Thomas transcribed the Zoom recordings verbatim beginning with Zoom transcription. Thomas listened to interviews carefully to correct errors, add punctuation, and insert notes about physical reactions of interviewer and interviewees. Interview quotes used in this paper have been edited for ease of reading by removing insertions, repetitions, and fillers such as *like*, *um*, and *you know*.

5.5. Data analysis

Self-study aims for "complementarity between research and practice" (Loughran, 2007, p. 15), so we conducted data analysis as we simultaneously continued to teach and collect data (Miles et al., 2014). This iterative process resulted in refinement of data collection practices (Loughran, 2007, p. 15). Exit tickets were collected after each class session and were the first data to be collected and examined. Each week after class, Rhianna read exit tickets independently, highlighting relevant quotes and noting trends. She shared initial analyses of exit tickets with Thomas later in the week during their weekly research meetings. Then Thomas reviewed the set of exit tickets collected from that week's class session, scanned them into our database, and offered additional insights in answer to our research question and continued teaching practice. Weekly research meetings also included designing exit ticket prompts that might elicit insightful reflection. In addition to discussing exit tickets, we discussed our own observations and reflections from the weekly class session focusing on Rhianna's enactment of the principles of Forum Theater. Thomas acted as a critical friend offering insights, gentle critiques, and suggestions according to his understanding of transformational education. We typed meeting notes and added them to the data set.

While initial data analysis occurred during the semester in which the class was taught, the majority of data analysis took place after the semester ended. Interviews were conducted and transcribed after grades

were submitted. Thomas and Rhianna read through the four interview transcripts together, referring to Zoom videos to better understand the meaning of TCs' responses. Together, we engaged in first level open coding of interview transcripts to detect recurring patterns across interviews (Miles et al., 2014). We then organized data into a spreadsheet so we could compare similarly coded data across interviews. We coded exit tickets using codes that emerged from interview transcripts and added exit ticket data to the spreadsheets. We found interview and exit ticket data produced very similar themes with no new codes emerging from exit tickets. After comparing exit ticket and interview data, we looked back to our meeting notes for further insights on themes.

6. Findings

Analysis indicated students viewed forum theater favorably as a teaching strategy. However, students consistently described hesitancy and nervousness around participation in forum theater. Upon further analysis, the researchers found both the TCs and the course instructor had difficulty overcoming the banking model of schooling in order to implement forum theater in the manner intended by Boal (1979). In this section, we describe both the benefits of forum theater as a pedagogical strategy and the challenges of implementing forum theater in a larger educational culture characterized by the banking model of education.

6.1. Benefits

Our analysis yielded three benefits of using forum theater in the Child Guidance Course. Across exit tickets and interviews, students consistently reported forum theater 1) led to visualization and embodiment of guidance techniques, 2) promoted a playful learning environment, and 3) allowed them to learn from their peers. These benefits were also noted in researcher reflections and meeting notes. Here we provide explication and evidence of these three findings.

6.1.1. Visualization and embodiment

The use of visuals and embodiment of practices have been found to support attainment of skills and understanding of new concepts (Winn, 1982). Further, disembodied pedagogical strategies that assume the mind is separate from the body, are characteristic of the banking model of education that serves to limit students' agency and participation (Darder, 2016). In our study, many TCs noted forum theater helped them visualize the teaching and guidance techniques advocated for in the course. During her interview, Bella said, "It helps you visualize how to intervene... or what specific point a teacher should go and intervene." On one exit ticket, Elizabeth wrote, "I found [forum theater] very useful as I am a visual learner and need a more hands-on approach." On her exit ticket, Anisah wrote, "I like watching the [forum] theater because I get to see reactions and solutions that I wouldn't think of." Anisah's comment indicates forum theater allowed her to see not only guidance strategies in action, but also a variety of possible child reactions. Thomas's October 4, 2021 reflection describes Rhianna acting in the role of teacher and spect-actors requesting increasingly stubborn child reactions to see how Thomas might respond. Spect-actors requested that the child in the scene act more stubbornly, refuse to follow the teacher's directions, and even knock over a chair. This embodied approach to learning child guidance techniques allowed for improvisation and boundary-pushing rather than simplification and standardization.

6.1.2. Playful learning environment

Play has long been recognized as a powerful learning format for young children, an act that enables children to perform beyond their current skill level according to contextual rules (Vygotsky, 1978). Facilitators of forum theater in teacher education report a playfulness that emerges when enacting forum theater with adults (Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010; Wrentschur, 2021) which allows for "cathartic release of tension through performance" (Cahnmann-Taylor &

Souto-Manning, 2010, p. 99). Unfortunately, play is rarely utilized in teacher education spaces despite its potential to revitalize TCs' playfulness, encourage creativity, and promote relationships (Diaz-Varela & Wright, 2019). In our study, we found several TCs described the learning environment as playful and expressed joy during forum theater activities. They demonstrated this joy and playfulness even though they also reported feeling nervous about participating in theater exercises and even when course content included difficult topics such as discipline disparities associated with racial and cultural oppression in schools. Researcher notes include accounts of students laughing and smiling with each other during whole and small group theater activities. The class seemed to take particular joy in one student's accurate and committed portrayal of a young child. Anisah wrote, "Today's [forum theater] was funny and informative." In an interview, Sophia contrasted forum theater with techniques used in more traditional university classrooms,

When we go to some of our classes, it's sometimes very serious ... We have quizzes and we really have to, like, study and just memorize a lot of things ... When I think back about this class, I just remember a lot of laughing ... Even if it was uncomfortable, it was like it was a fun type of uncomfortable where you're still laughing. So I feel like there's really a positive emotion that's attached to that learning experience that can really help you retain that information. It's not just stressed about learning the PowerPoint.

6.1.3. Learning from peers

Boal designed Forum Theater to elicit solutions to community social justice issues from community members themselves (Boal, 1979). This is consistent with Freire's notion of transformational pedagogy in which knowledge only emerges "through invention and reinvention, through the restless, impatient, continuing, hopeful inquiry human beings pursue in the world, with the world, and with each other" (Freire, 1970, p. 72). Our analysis revealed forum theater in the Child Guidance classroom was somewhat successful at evoking solutions from TCs rather than reliance on established *best practices* provided by the instructor or the textbook which may not be best for the specific context and may not be transformative. For example, October 18, 2021 researcher notes document a TC suggesting that when a toddler spills milk, instead of reprimanding, the teacher should gently direct the child to a drawer of towels organized for the purpose of children cleaning up their own spills. On an exit ticket, Elizabeth wrote, "the different scenarios + solutions ideas from peers help me think outside the box." Similarly, Evelyn wrote, "I found it useful because we could talk through scenarios and be helpful to each other." In an interview, Jacqueline explained, "That's what I really liked about [forum theater]; it's not like completely ... closed-ended I guess ... we could still like ... change it up." These students reported forum theater, in which the Joker facilitates idea generation from actors and audience members, supported their creative problem solving and collaboration skills, skills necessary for breaking down harmful norms of school discipline practices.

6.2. Challenges

While our study revealed clear benefits of forum theater in the Child Guidance classroom, we also found both the instructor and the students consistently struggled to overcome the banking model of education. Students' adherence to the banking model of education, which they had likely been socialized into for most of their schooling (Bybee, 2020), is evident in their hesitancy to participate in forum theater. Rhianna and TCs demonstrated difficulty letting go of the banking model of education through a focus on memorization and by conceiving of the instructor as knower.

6.2.1. Hesitancy to participate in forum theater

A willingness to participate in theater pedagogies that explore difficult social topics requires comfort with bodily expression (Boal,

1979) as well as feelings of safety and trust (Jacobs & Perez, 2023). Despite beginning the semester with community-building and movement exercises, nearly all participants reported feelings of shyness and intimidation. In an interview, Nicole said, "When you're in a room full of a bunch of adults, it's kind of like, oh, what if they're judging me or... everybody's watching me." On her September 20, 2021 exit ticket, Harper wrote, "[T]here are times where we could talk out the situation rather than act it out ... I know participation can be hard so people may be more willing [to talk rather than act]." It was often difficult to recruit volunteer actors during class sessions resulting in the same TCs and Rhianna serving as actors repeatedly. When no students volunteered to participate, the instructor sometimes used what one TC termed "vol-untold" strategies to increase the variety of actors participating in theater, asking a specific student if they might be willing to play a role. Often our teacher-researcher meetings included discussions about how to increase participation in whole group forum theater with Thomas pointing out that TCs would become teachers who would need to be playful with children and comfortable leading a classroom during university observations. A comment during a conference presentation helped us expand our thinking about TC hesitancy to participate. An attendee suggested hesitancy might be interpreted as TC resistance to curriculum or Rhianna's authority. Resistance is a communicative act often taken up by students who have less power than their instructors and should be interpreted carefully when seeking a more democratic classroom culture (Knight Abowitz, 2000). We wonder if small group theater, which is discussed as an implication later in this paper, allows for less instructor surveillance and that is why it received less resistance in this class.

6.2.2. A focus on memorization

Another sign that Rhianna and the TCs had difficulty letting go of the banking model of education was that TCs seemed to conceive of course learning as memorization of procedures. The following excerpt from Nicole's interview is especially revealing.

It would have taken a lot more work with the students' part to... learn it, more studying of the things, more going back and reviewing. Not that we didn't, but it was definitely a lot easier to like, oh remember in class when this happened, then we did this, this, and this versus to go look at the Power Point because I forgot what we're supposed to do after step two, or whatever. I do think it helped with the memorization. And I think if it would have just been PowerPoint, it might not have necessarily stuck as well. Because I, even now, I can think back of times when I was like, oh remember when this happened in class, this is how this person reacted and this is how they didn't react. And this is what we were supposed to do next, or what we should have done next versus... be[ing] like well now, I have to go back to the PowerPoint because I can't remember.

Nicole contrasts forum theater with traditional lecture approaches to university education but conceives of both as methods to help students memorize information given by the instructor. Sophia conveyed a similar sentiment in her interview:

I think it would have been not as impressed in my mind cause we're learning so much information ... it really helped just retaining the information... having that experience just also helps you think back to that class, like oh, I remember I acted that out... [or another student acted it out]... it'll help you go back to that moment, and just really think about the information that we had learned.

Meeting notes indicate Rhianna also had difficulty letting go of a focus on memorization, especially regarding a procedure for peer conflict resolution that focused on teachers scaffolding children's development of solutions to their own conflict (Adams & Wittmer, 2001). September 30, 2021 meeting notes indicate Rhianna suggested displaying the procedures for conflict resolution as a guide during forum theater because she knew TCs would *stray away* from the procedure and

they often *have difficulty implementing it correctly*.

While course content did consist of specific procedures with defined steps such as peer conflict resolution and Bailey's (2004) *Describe, Name, Acknowledge* procedure, the aims of the course went far beyond memorization of these procedures. In class and in researcher meetings, Rhianna explained one objective for the course was for TCs to gain skill in making pedagogical decisions that reflect their own values and the particular sociocultural context in which they teach.

Our self-study reveals, even with the implementation of forum theater, TCs conceived of their role in the child guidance classroom as memorizing procedures. Memorization of procedures stands in contrast to the skill of constructing a response that reflects their own values and a unique teaching situation. The focus on memorization indicates TCs and Rhianna had a difficult time overcoming the banking model of education. Researcher meeting notes record Rhianna's concern that she was actually implementing role play to practice predetermined steps rather than forum theater to support creative idea-generation grounded in students' cultural knowledge.

6.2.3. Instructor as giver-of-knowledge

Related to the finding that TCs understood the purpose of forum theater to be memorization of procedures, our self-study also revealed students and Rhianna conceived of the instructor as giver-of-knowledge rather than a Joker who facilitates conversation, complicates easy solutions, and supports the development of critical consciousness. Jacqueline reported forum theater was "not like completely ... close-ended," that she and her classmates were "part of it, and [could] change it up" but at the same time, she "would kind of get like a better idea from [instructor] feedback as well." Bella reiterated that Rhianna often used her role as facilitator of forum theater to point out "how we might not be doing it correctly." Bella explained, "I like that you [the instructor] were able to guide if something didn't go the way that it was-like what would the best way to solve the problem." Nicole pointed out she perceived the forum theater exercises to be close-ended, guided by Rhianna through prompts such as, "this might be a little bit better, or we can try to avoid using this language" so that they led to a predetermined "end result that [was] the goal that we were trying to achieve." While Nicole spoke about this aspect of the class activity as positive, it points out the stagnation that results when instructors act as a giver-of-knowledge.

Our researcher meeting notes confirm Rhianna struggled reconciling her traditional role of instructor and the role of Joker. She often took on the role of teacher in forum theater instead of acting exclusively as the Joker. In the role of Joker, she often offered solutions rather than asking questions. In a September 2021 meeting, Thomas reminded her that forum theater "can be used to try out strategies [she had] taught as well as novel strategies. [TCs] may come up with something that is a new and positive solution, or they may come up with something that needs questioning by the facilitator or spect-actors." Rhianna reflected that when actors and spect-actors acted outside of the procedure that had been taught, she often reverted to giver-of-knowledge, providing alternative solutions or steering them back to the instructor-authorized procedure. In contrast, a Joker asks questions for consciousness-raising and to support participants in drawing their own conclusions. For example, after teaching the TCs a peer conflict resolution procedure (Adams & Wittmer, 2001), Rhianna facilitated forum theater. When the person acting in the role of teacher offered the children possible solutions to their disagreement, Rhianna stopped the action and reminded the class that the peer conflict resolution procedure requires that children come up with their own solutions. Ironically, Rhianna was not giving the TCs enough space in forum theater to come up with their own solutions to the given scenario. A more proficient Joker might have let the scenario play out to the end and waited to see if spect-actors had recommendations or might pause the action themselves. If spect-actors did not make comment, the Joker might ask, "Who in that scenario got to practice coming up with creative solutions (the teacher or the children)? What opportunities did the children in this scenario have to

learn that there are multiple solutions to any problem? Who held the power in that scenario as it was acted out, and revised. At this point in the September 2021 researcher meeting, Rhianna concluded, "This resulted in the students wanting me to show them how to 'do it right.'"

6.2.4. Reality check as check on instructor power

Authors concluded the reality check served as an important check on the instructor's power in the classroom. The reality check occurred after a scenario had been presented, acted out, and revised. At this point in the forum theater routine, Rhianna would facilitate a conversation about how realistic a scenario and its proposed solutions felt. She might prompt, "Discuss with your partner if you think this scenario would really go the way we acted it. Would the child likely respond this way? What else might have happened?" Meeting notes indicate Rhianna and Thomas recognized through discussion that the reality check often seemed to make space for the TCs to break from performing as the instructor wanted them to and provide more critical conversations about child guidance techniques in practice. On exit tickets, Gift wrote, "the reality check was one of the most helpful parts because it gave me a perspective of different views," and Sophia commented, "The reality check helped put the possible scenarios in different perspective of the reality of the different outcomes." In her interview, Nicole concluded, "I do think that it [reality check] definitely helped being able to analyze situations together as a class after acting it out."

7. Discussion

The oppressive nature of discipline practices in the United States necessitates transformational approaches to teacher education in Child Guidance courses. We sought to raise TC critical consciousness around discipline practices and develop TC skill in facilitating positive child guidance through the use of forum theater. However, the effectiveness of pedagogical tools, such as forum theater, is always mediated by the context in which they are taken up, the worldview of the students who utilize it, and facilitation by educators (Thomas et al., 2022). In this self-study, we found the encompassing nature of the banking model of education in the U.S. context had profound influence on the effectiveness of forum theater. While there is evidence that forum theater supported embodied learning, playfulness, and learning from peers, we found the culture of the classroom still operated within the banking model of education as evidenced by student hesitancy to participate, a focus on memorization of procedures, and positioning the instructor as giver-of-knowledge.

Freire (1970) warns that those who are socialized into the banking model of education and have inhabited positions of power "almost always bring with them the marks of their origin; their prejudices and their deformations, which include a lack of confidence in the people's ability to think, to want, and to know" (p. 60). This was evident in Rhianna's difficulty letting go of her position as giver-of-knowledge and fully enacting forum theater as a pedagogy that promotes creativity and collaborative inquiry. She often used theater activities to teach a predetermined procedure and resorted to giving advice when acting in the role of Joker.

TCs are not positioned as constructors-of-knowledge in their long-time roles as students within the banking model of education and expressed discomfort when invited to take active roles in embodied pedagogy that positioned them as creators-of-knowledge. This may be due to what Freire (1970) describes as the domesticating effect of banking education in which "the more students work at storing the deposits entrusted to them, the less they develop the critical consciousness which would result from their intervention in the world as transformers of that world" (p. 73). Their reluctance and discomfort may also be considered an act of resistance to additional oppression by a university instructor (Knight Abowitz, 2000) who acted as all-knowing.

Another element to consider is that the university course in which this study took place is a low-level course taken by TCs who have not yet

been accepted into the Teacher Education Program and may not be fully committed to a career in education. Commenting on our initial findings as presented in a conference paper, one anonymous reviewer suggested TCs enrolled in this early-program Child Guidance course did not have “enough ‘contextualized problems’ and ‘teaching experiences’ to explore through forum theater.” Indeed, Thomas observed TCs who had experience working in classrooms and those who are parents often seemed more likely to contribute as spect-actors. We recognize transformational pedagogies, including forum theater, are designed to bring together people with common experiences of oppression (Boal, 1979; Freire, 1970) and that people with limited experience working in oppressive teaching contexts may have difficulty fully engaging in forum theater. However, the initial goal of transformational pedagogy is to raise critical consciousness and then to identify shared problems and innovate solutions (Boal, 1979; Freire, 1970). Despite the difficulties implementing forum theater, we do feel such goals are appropriate for university students who are interested in teaching and have often spent 13 years as students experiencing and observing problematic discipline practices within the U.S. education system.

Raising TC critical consciousness around punitive and racially disparate discipline practices is central to the goals of the Child Guidance course. Rhianna begins the course with a brief introduction to U.S. history of oppressive and culturally subtractive discipline practices in schools including forced boarding schools for Indigenous children, the school-to-prison pipeline, and discipline disparities associated with race and ability. TCs are required to explore their own identities and biases and consider how those might affect their approaches to child guidance through artistic representations and teaching dilemmas. Despite this focus, TC critical consciousness did not emerge as a theme in our analysis of exit tickets and interview transcripts. Perhaps this is because interview and exit ticket prompts focused on forum theater, and preservice teachers did not see consciousness-raising as something specific to forum theater activities but rather a general feature of the course. However, researcher reflections and meeting notes provide evidence that TCs’ critical consciousness increased during the semester through problematization of common discipline practices. Problematization occurred during class discussions, video analysis, and forum theater. A revealing example can be found in Rhianna’s October 4, 2021 memo about the problematization of a teaching video that had been promoted online as best practice and that she had used in previous iterations of the course without critical analysis. Rhianna documented the following points she and TCs discussed after viewing the video: the teacher seemed to be giving one child more power than the other, the teacher acted as if she was providing the child an opportunity to come up with a solution but the teacher had one right solution in mind, and the teacher may be exhibiting bias against a Black child. One student, an active participant in forum theater, asserted, *If we would have acted it out in class that way, the class would have brought up all these problems*. This indicates the preservice teachers had grown accustomed to problematizing common practice, evidence of their critical consciousness and ability to go beyond memorization of procedures.

7.1. Implications for our own practice

Consistent with self-study methodology, findings led us to implement changes to our practice at the end of the semester under study in this manuscript and in subsequent iterations of the course. We outline four changes to practice here.

1. It was important for Rhianna to distinguish between role play to practice established procedures and forum theater as a tool to raise critical consciousness, identify shared experiences, and innovate solutions. To achieve this, Rhianna began labeling dramatic activities to practice preconceived procedures as *role play* or *reader’s theater*. She followed up such activities with forum theater sessions in which TCs could compose and analyze responses to a chosen

scenario. Responses might include procedures taught in the course or a novel solution, and the efficacy of any procedure could be scrutinized.

2. To reduce student discomfort with performing in front of the entire class, we utilized small group configurations for rehearsing initial scenes in forum theater. The small group format resulted in less instructor surveillance which might also have increased student comfort. Based on a recommendation given during interviews, Rhianna began subsequent semesters of the course with time for TCs to socialize and play outside together to build community before implementing forum theater.
3. In response to student focus on memorization, Rhianna worked with TCs to develop a set of *guiding principles* they could use when making pedagogical and ethical decisions in their future teaching. These principles were guidelines for decision-making rather than a set of pre-determined strategies. Rhianna displayed guiding principles so TCs could draw from them when enacting solutions and evaluating proposed actions during reality checks. See Table 1 for guiding principles created during the semester under study.
4. Based on feedback from a reviewer for this journal, Rhianna began using data sources for future research that capture the social and embodied nature of forum theater in-the-moment. Sources such as field notes and video recording might help us understand the nuanced nature of communication through movement that written reflections and interviews cannot capture.

8. Trustworthiness

The trustworthiness of self-study research depends upon researchers’ dedicated actions to seeing their own work clearly through analysis of multiple data sources and interactions with colleagues, students, and the literature (Loughran, 2007). In this study, we utilized multiple forms of student-generated and practitioner-generated data. In recognition that it can be difficult for practitioners to identify mistakes and contradictions in their own practice (Loughran, 2004), Thomas acted as observer and critical friend to Rhianna, and we took into consideration the analyses of outside reviewers who provided feedback on this research at a conference and through manuscript review.

9. Conclusion

Critical drama pedagogies are employed by teacher educators to promote critical consciousness raising, perspective-taking, and comfort with socially just action (Cahnmann-Taylor & Souto-Manning, 2010; Jacobs & Perez, 2023). However, there is limited literature describing the difficulties TCs and teacher educators might encounter when engaging in transformational drama pedagogies. See Desai (2017), Harman and McClure (2011), and Powers and Duffy (2016) for exceptions. Using self-study, our research found forum theater offers tremendous affordances for playfulness, embodied learning, and constructing knowledge with peers; we also found Rhianna underestimated the power of the banking culture of education to domesticate (Giroux, 1992) and mechanize (Macedo, 2000) transformational pedagogies. While not always flattering, our paper demonstrates candid self-study methods that include dialogue with a critical friend, a reviewer, and an audience member. We offer a firsthand account of the struggles a teacher educator socialized and working within the banking model of education encountered when enacting forum theater. Recognizing “self-study involves a confident commitment to discovering new paths and reinventing one’s practice in the service of others” (Pithouse-Morgan, 2022, p. 119), we share implications for our practice that might be adapted to other contexts. We move forward in our teaching with deeper understanding of the responsibility of teacher educators to stimulate conversations, analyses, and actions that promote critical consciousness and TC agency.

Table 1

Guiding principles Co-constructed with teacher candidates.

The teacher's role is to:

- teach social/emotional skills through scaffolding (instead of punishment)
- acknowledge and affirm children's emotions
- control own emotions (practicing mindfulness and patience)
- take into consideration children's individual skills, experiences, and needs
- help all children feel included

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CRediT authorship contribution statement

Rhianna K. Thomas: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Funding acquisition, Formal analysis, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Thomas Korang:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Investigation, Formal analysis, Data curation.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare the following financial interests/personal relationships which may be considered as potential competing interests: Thomas Korang reports travel was provided by Glass Family Research Institute for Child and Family Studies. If there are other authors, they declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

Data availability

The data that has been used is confidential.

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